TISCO, Mody continued to target Ratan at every opportunity and reserved the harshest words for him, for several years. Ratan, however, would respond differently, with grace. This came to the fore on the occasion of the '75 years of Industrial Harmony' at TISCO, held on 13 February 2004.

Muthuraman had, without consulting Ratan, invited Mody to the function. Ratan was only informed later. 'I was nervous, I could even lose my job, I thought,' Muthuraman says. Instead, he was in for a surprise. He received a copy of his letter with a small handwritten note pinned to its left corner. In his characteristic calligraphic hand, Ratan had written, 'I think you displayed graciousness in inviting RHM. Such an action shows that we are broadminded and unbiased.'

Perhaps another instance of this extraordinary quality in Ratan was evident when Cyrus Mistry was replaced as chairman, Tata Sons. Hussain, who was a director on the board of Tata Sons, had abstained when the resolution to replace Mistry was moved. This had hurt Ratan. But he is a person who can take another point of view, says Hussain: 'I knew even if I abstained, I will not be persona non grata.' After the voting, he called on Ratan who told him, 'I knew that you will abstain.' Hussain replied that he had abstained as he was not aware of the reasons why Mistry was being removed. Ratan replied: 'If I were you, I would have abstained.' Hussain remarks, 'See the bigness of the man.'

Recalling a similar instance, Bhaskar Bhat says that the kind of humility Ratan displays is extraordinarily rare. In 1994, during a business review meeting, Xerxes Desai was insistent that the group's jewellery business would make profits, though it had been in the red for some years. Ratan queried whether Titan was a watch company making jewellery or a jewellery company making watches, recalls Bhat. He was indirectly inquiring if the entry into the new segment was a carefully thought-out strategy. It was his typical way of challenging the management. But when the jewellery division won the JRD QV Award in 2011, Ratan acknowledged the wisdom in Desai's analysis. In the meeting he candidly said, 'We were all wrong and Xerxes was right.'

Even in the most trying situations, Ratan's understanding of the holistic circumstances can be exceptional. When the Nano Singur site was flooded in 2007, Girish Wagh and M.B. Kulkarni had made a presentation to him at Bombay House regarding the steps that they would take to rectify the